



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

1979 Chevrolet Camaro Z28 Restoration Guide

Model Year 1979

Model	Chevrolet Camaro Z28 (2nd-gen F-body)
Engine	350 cid LM1 V8, 175 hp (170 CA), 4-barrel
Transmission	Close-ratio 4-speed or TH350 automatic
Production	84,877 Z28s of 282,571 Camaros — record year
Notable	1979-only air dam and fender louvers; U14 gauges standard

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

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Chapter 1 — The Record Year: Camaro in 1979

Chevrolet built 282,571 Camaros for 1979 — the model's biggest year ever — and 84,877 of them were Z28s at a \$6,115 sticker. The emissions era had cut the horsepower figures, but not the formula: the Z28 remained a handling package with a 350, stripes, spoilers, and the best suspension in the showroom. For restorers the 1979 car is the sweet spot of late second-generation ownership — record production means parts and knowledge, and the one-year trim details mean the identity work still matters. This guide does that work: codes first, then metal, then paint.

Chapter 2 — What Makes the 1979 Z28 Different

- **1979-only front:** the air dam now wraps around the fenders and the fender louvers are new this year — year-specific parts on the most-produced Z28 ever.
- **Flat-black scoop:** the hood scoop treatment is finished in flat black as part of the '79 package.
- **Gauges standard:** the instrument package (tach, voltmeter, temperature, clock) is included on Z28 and Berlinetta.
- **California split:** 170-hp tune and no four-speed available on any California Camaro — a documented regional specification, not a defect.

Chapter 3 — VIN and Cowl-Tag Decoding

The 13-character VIN reads **1** Chevrolet, **Q** (Sport Coupe, Rally Sport, and Z28; **S** is Berlinetta), **87** coupe, the engine letter — **D** 250 six, **G** 305, **L** 350 — **9** for 1979, **N** Norwood or **L** Van Nuys, and the sequence. Documented Z28s read 1Q87L9N... — note that the VIN alone proves a 350 coupe, never a Z28.



The Norwood cowl tag carries the trump card: a **Z28** stamping in the tag's option area, alongside trim (documented example: 62R tan standard vinyl), two-tone paint codes (69L/69U), A51 buckets, and the secondary interior color code. Van Nuys cars are documented the other way — the build sheet, hunted above the fuel tank and under the seats. Which plant built the car decides where the proof lives.

Chapter 4 — The Z28's 350: The 175-Horsepower Net-Era Specification

The Z28's LM1-family 350 makes 175 hp (170 in California tune) — SAE net, through dual exhaust, a four-barrel, and the full emissions-era hardware. Comparing that number to a 1970 gross rating is a category error this guide refuses: the net system, gearing, and weight make the 1979 car a different, slower, and far more civilized instrument. Restoration doctrine is completeness: the AIR pump, EGR, and associated hardware are factory equipment whose presence or documented absence defines an original car — particularly for California-delivered examples, where the specification differs in writing.

Chapter 5 — The Rest of the Line: 250, 305, and the Berlinetta

Context for judging any 1979 Camaro: the 250 six (21,913 cars), the 305 2-barrel (chosen by 138,197 V8 buyers at \$235), the 350 in non-Z28 tune (122,461 at \$360), and the Berlinetta (67,236) — the luxury coupe that replaced the Type LT and borrowed the Z28's gauge package. Clone material comes from exactly this list: Berlinettas and 350 Sport Coupes wear the parts; the cowl tag and build sheet decide (Chapters 3 and 16).

Chapter 6 — Transmissions and Axles

The Z28's close-ratio four-speed was ordered by 18,987 buyers at no extra charge over the TH350 automatic — and was unavailable anywhere in California, on any Camaro. Across the line, 38,604 buyers paid \$64 for the G80 Positraction axle and 20,714 took the sport suspension. Record transmission and axle stamps before removal; on late second-generation cars the axle code is a build-sheet fact that the restoration keeps or loses in the first afternoon.

Chapter 7 — Suspension, Brakes, Steering, and Wheels

The Z28 package's heavy-duty suspension and sway bars remain its mechanical signature, over power front discs and rear drums. The five-spoke Z28 wheel and the graphics package are coded parts; wheels carry dates and the spare is part of the set. Steering and bar hardware are verified against the package specification — a '79 Z28 restored on base-Camaro bars is wearing the wrong skeleton under the right paint.

Chapter 8 — Paint, Stripes, and the Z28 Graphics

Paint and trim codes live on the cowl tag (the documented example: two-tone 69 Dark Brown over tan vinyl). The Z28's stripes, fender louvers, wrapped air dam, and flat-black scoop form the 1979-only visual package — all reproduced, all precisely placed in the factory literature. Match the placement documents, not the loudest catalog photograph, and record the tag codes in the car's file before the first panel comes off.



Chapter 9 — Production Numbers and Rarity

1979 Camaro	Built	Note
All models	282,571	record Camaro year
Z28	84,877	\$6,115 sticker
Berlinetta	67,236	replaced Type LT
Z28 close-ratio 4-speed	18,987	no-charge option; none in CA
G80 Positraction (all)	38,604	\$64 option

Rarity on the 1979 Z28 is a quality gradient, not a scarcity claim: four-speeds, documented California cars, and intact emissions hardware are the differentiators inside the 84,877.

Chapter 10 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

Second-generation rust: rear frame rails, trunk and floor pans, lower quarters, door bottoms, cowl and windshield corners, subframe mounts. The 1978–81 cars add their urethane nose and fascia — check for cracks, sag, and the fit that betrays a swapped nose. T-top cars where fitted get the roof-channel inspection. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 14).

Chapter 11 — Restoration Sequence for the 1979 Z28

- **1. Document** — VIN plate, cowl tag (Norwood Z28 stamp), engine suffix and dates, transmission and axle stamps, photographs.
- **2. Name the car honestly** — Z28, Berlinetta, or Sport Coupe with Z28 parts. The tag and build sheet decide.
- **3. Structure first** — subframe mounts and rails before cosmetic metal.
- **4. Disassemble by system**; emissions hardware inventoried and preserved; louvers, air dam, and scoop tagged as year-specific parts.
- **5. Drivetrain to its documented tune** — 49-state and California specifications are different restorations; pick the car's own.
- **6. Paint and graphics last**, to the cowl-tag codes and placement documents.

Chapter 12 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	Z28 350	Line 350 (LM1)	305 (LG3)
Rating	175 hp (170 CA)	170 hp (165 CA)	130 hp (125 CA)
Induction	4-bbl	4-bbl	2-bbl
Exhaust	dual	per model	per model
VIN letter	L	L	G

All ratings SAE net. California figures are factory tunes, printed because they decide originality on California-delivered cars.

Chapter 13 — Options and Factory Details

- G80 Positraction (\$64; 38,604 buyers) — the axle code proves it.
- Sport suspension on non-Z28 cars (\$41; 20,714).



- Wide-ratio 4-speed on the line (\$135; 10,796) — distinct from the Z28's close-ratio box.
- U14 instrumentation — standard on Z28 and Berlinetta.
- Dual horns (U05) and special instrumentation were standard Z28 content per the marque references.

Chapter 14 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- Norwood car: Z28 stamping found on the cowl tag; Van Nuys car: build-sheet hunt planned before money moves.
- VIN engine letter L (350) — necessary, never sufficient.
- 1979-only hardware present: wrapping air dam, fender louvers, flat-black scoop — all dated to the car.
- Emissions hardware inventoried; California-tune cars verified against their specification, not 'corrected.'
- Four-speed cars: transmission codes recorded (and none factory-built for California).
- Rust map (Ch. 10) with photos; fascia fit and cracks inspected.
- Wheel set and spare matched and dated.

Chapter 15 — Casting Numbers, Suffix Codes, and Date Codes

The block's stamped suffix names the application; castings and dates corroborate, preceding the build and sitting close to it. On net-era cars the emissions components carry their own dating discipline — a complete, correctly dated AIR/EGR system is originality you can see, and its absence is priced by everyone who knows these cars. Keep the stamped evidence legible through the rebuild; do not deck away the pad.

Chapter 16 — Clones and Conversions: Tells That Matter

84,877 real Z28s mean the clone pressure is lower than 1970's — and the surviving fraud is accordingly lazier: stripes and louvers on a Berlinetta. Tells, in authority order: the Norwood cowl-tag stamp or the Van Nuys build sheet; the engine suffix; the package hardware (bars, gauges, suspension); and the factory's regional rule — a factory four-speed 'California Z28' contradicts the order book. An honest Berlinetta is a pleasant car; it is priced as one.

Chapter 17 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed that cannot be traced to factory service literature. The discipline stands: clean chased threads, lubrication as the manual specifies, the printed pattern in at least three steps, re-checks after the first heat cycle where called for — and factory values for subframe and suspension hardware. Values come from the 1979 Chevrolet service manual in Sources; record what you used.



Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- 1979 Chevrolet Camaro factory service manual
- Chevrolet 350 small block engine rebuild kit
- 1970-1981 Camaro restoration parts
- 1979 Chevrolet Camaro parts catalog

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Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Chevrolet factory literature.** the 1979 Chevrolet service manual and dealer ordering information — authority for torque values, specifications, and option definitions
- **NastyZ28 / SS396 marque restoration references.** 1979 Camaro engine tables, VIN structure, cowl-tag decodes, and monthly production-end VIN data
- **Hagerty valuation research.** 1979 Camaro production totals, model mix, and period pricing
- **Chevrolet production records as compiled by the registries.** option take-rates (four-speed, G80, suspensions) used in Chapter 9

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first 1979 Chevrolet Camaro Z28 or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

Eighty-five thousand built, and the good ones still stop traffic. Restore the car your cowl tag describes — louvers, scoop, codes and all.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team